

Incidental vs. Dreamed

The Dreaming is a constantly shifting place. By far, the majority of chimerical objects and beings are fleeting and ephemeral, dreamed into existence for a few seconds before evaporating like smoke. This type of chimera is called *incidental chimera*. Incidental chimera are the most common kind of chimera found in the physical world, spun out of daydreams and idle thoughts. Mortals cannot see them, and they quickly succumb to the ravages of Banality, especially if they are removed from the area where they came into being.

In contrast, *dreamed chimera* spring from the minds of changelings and mortals, and are the most common type of chimera found in the Dreaming. Dreamed chimera are hardier than incidental chimera, able to survive indefinitely after the reverie that created them ends.

Inanimate vs. Animate

Inanimate chimera are the building blocks of the dreaming, and may be as simple as a stone or as complex as spidersilk. They are dreams of cloth and metals and precious jewels, springing from the dreams of individuals, or the collective dreams of humanity. They may also be secondary products of chimerical creatures: Spider chimera produce silk, which can be collected and used as raw material.

Inanimate chimera may manifest half-formed and malleable, or they may be fully-realized objects of art. Virtually every piece of beauty or importance in the Autumn world has a chimerical counterpart — in Paris of the Kingdom of Neustria, Notre Dame Cathedral towers high and breathtaking; farther south, in the Hellenic Empire's Dreaming, the Acropolis gleams new and whole under the light of a Mediterranean sun.

Not all fully-realized inanimate chimera are durable, however. Typically, only places of great creativity or those that represent the hopes and dreams of a people keep their reflection in the Dreaming. A pancake house may have a reflection in the Dreaming, but it is crude and in a state of flux, changing with every new customer that comes through the doors.

By contrast, animate chimera almost always form fully realized. They may not necessarily be sentient, but non-sentient animate chimera are difficult to tell apart from those with true sentience. Like inanimate chimera, animates may be harvested for Glamour or raw crafting components.

Non-sentient vs. Sentient

Non-sentient chimera can appear to be intelligent and alive, but even the cleverest riddler or canny hunter is little more than a set of preordained instincts and preprogrammed behavior.

Sentient chimera may not be animate, but are otherwise fully alive in every sense of the world. They possess self-awareness, intelligence, and free will, and are capable of self-determination.

Shaping Dreamstuff

The truly gifted can create amazing works of beauty and function with little more than raw dreamstuff and the force of their own will, shaping their dreams into reality. At one time, all changelings could do such a thing, drawing incredible weapons, clothing, and foodstuffs out of thin air with little more than a gesture and a passing thought. Though all changelings still possess the potential, dream manipulation has become an increasingly-difficult skill in the Autumn world, and those that learn find they prefer the refined Art of Oneiromancy to raw exertion of their will. Instead of creating and banishing their accoutrements at a whim, changelings make the most of their panoplies and everyday goods in a more permanent fashion: reshaping inanimate chimera using mortal crafting techniques.

Forged Chimera

Forged chimera, those crafted by nockers and other talented artisans, fall somewhere between the categories of chimera into their own classification. Like chimerical items, they are constructed out of materials gathered from the Dreaming and are put together in laboratories, workshops, and garages. Clockwork and robotic servants, steeds, and pets are quite common in larger urban areas, especially in recent years with the resurgence of steampunk's popularity amongst the masses.

Giving life to such chimera is a more difficult accomplishment. Even though changelings understand that their dreams have power and can be shaped, surprisingly few have the focus, motivation, or raw power to dream a new chimera specific to their needs. It is less difficult to find a chimera to coax, coerce, or force into the forged shell, but that is fraught with its own perils and drawbacks.

Most artisans who forge chimera are content to give it a semblance of life instead of actual life. Most forged chimera are non-sentient, but can surprisingly act in intelligent ways. Guardian chimera may have an amazing ability with a blade, hunters may display instincts on par with an experienced tracker, and a chimerical butler might be able to hold a conversation, but all of these are illusionary at best. Non-sentient forged chimera behave according to the wishes of those that constructed them, filling the role for which they were created and nothing more.

Though it begins with no independent thought or willpower, a forged chimera can spontaneously develop self-awareness. This has been a rare occurrence in the past, but has become more commonplace as mortal technology leaps towards true artificial intelligence, and more people become afraid of (or excited for) the day when robots and computers gain self-awareness.

Voile

Voile is the most common example of crafted chimera. It is faerie garb, created from the chimerical equivalents of mundane cloth, leathers, and metals. Much like mortal seamstresses and fashion designers, a thriving fashion industry exists in market